

Understanding Language and Early Language Development

An exhaustive academic monograph investigating the epistemological nature of human language, structural linguistics (phonetics, phonology, morphology, syntax), the psychological architecture of first and second language acquisition (Krashen, Chomsky, Vygotsky), the Foundational Literacy and Numeracy (FLN / NIPUN Bharat) continuum, constitutional safeguards, the sociolinguistic mosaic of Assam, asset-based multilingualism and translanguaging pedagogy, Language Across the Curriculum (LAC), M.A.K. Halliday's functional taxonomy, and Jim Cummins' BICS/CALP framework.

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● Curriculum Session 2026 • Exhaustive Master Reference Edition

SYLLABUS ARCHITECTURE & MODULE WEIGHTAGE

Total: 35 External Marks

Unit 1

10 Marks

Language & Communication in Society

Nature of Language vs. Knowledge, Hockett's Design Features, Semiotics, Sapir-Whorf Hypothesis, Cultural Identity.

Unit 2

10 Marks

Language Acquisition & Learning

Krashen's 5 Hypotheses, L_1 to L_2 Transition, NIPUN Bharat FLN Architecture, Phonetics, Phonology & Morphology.

Unit 3

9 Marks

Diversity & Multilingualism

Constitutional Provisions (Articles 343–351), Linguistic Map of Assam, Translanguaging, Three-Language Formula.

Unit 4

6 Marks

Language Across Curriculum (LAC)

Bullock Report Rationale, Halliday's 7 Micro-Functions, Cummins' Dual Iceberg Hypothesis (BICS vs. CALP Matrix).

1

Language and Communication in Society

Epistemological Nature, Charles Hockett's Design Features, Semiotic Architecture & Cultural Identity

Weightage:
10 Marks

In contemporary linguistic philosophy, **Language** is defined as a dynamic, rule-governed system of arbitrary vocal, manual, or written symbols through which human beings communicate thoughts, conceptualize physical and social reality, and construct meaning. Language is not merely a passive conduit for transferring pre-existing packets of data; it serves as the foundational **symbolic scaffolding of human cognition**.

To understand early childhood development, teacher trainees must explore the reciprocal relationship between the **Nature of Language** and the **Nature of Knowledge**:

- **THE NATURE OF KNOWLEDGE (জ্ঞানৰ প্ৰকৃতি)**

Philosophical epistemology categorizes human knowledge into *Procedural Knowledge* ("knowing how" to swim, balance, or knead clay) and *Propositional Knowledge* ("knowing that" an assertion is objectively true or false).

Propositional knowledge cannot exist without verbal encoding. When a primary student internalizes that "Water boils at 100°C" or that "Plants require sunlight for photosynthesis", the conceptual schema is formed, manipulated, stored, and retrieved through linguistic structures.
- **SOCIAL CONSTRUCTIVISM (VYGOTSKIAN SEMIOTIC MEDIATION)**

Lev Vygotsky proved that knowledge is never transmitted into a passive mind like liquid into an empty jar. Rather, knowledge is co-constructed through collaborative social dialogue.

Language functions as the ultimate **psychological tool** (semiotic mediator). A child first experiences speech socially as an external tool of interaction (*Social Speech*). Over time, this dialogue is internalized as self-directed guidance (*Private Speech*), which eventually crystallizes into silent verbal thought (*Inner Speech*).

● **LANGUAGE AS THE EPISTEMOLOGICAL GATEWAY TO SCHOOL CURRICULA:**

DISCIPLINARY SUBJECT	LINGUISTIC DEMAND & COGNITIVE FUNCTION	ILLUSTRATIVE CLASSROOM MANIFESTATION
Mathematics (গণিত)	Translating natural narrative language into relational, symbolic algebraic syntax. Mathematical logic requires precise lexical comprehension of comparative vocabulary (<i>difference, product, quotient, multiple</i>).	In the word problem: " <i>Rahim had 12 betel nuts and gave 5 to Mina; how many remain?</i> ", the child must decode semantic subtraction before applying numerical calculations.

Science & EVS (বিজ্ঞান আৰু পৰিৱেশ)	Hypothesis formulation, observing physical anomalies, articulating cause-and-effect sequences, and categorizing botanical/zoological specimens.	Formulating predictions: " <i>If we immerse this dry clay block in water, bubbles will escape because air is trapped inside the microscopic pores.</i> "
Social Sciences (সমাজ বিজ্ঞান)	Deconstructing historical causality, evaluating civic perspectives, resolving geographic dilemmas, and exercising social empathy.	Discussing why riverine communities in the Brahmaputra valley construct traditional bamboo houses on stilts (<i>Chang Ghar</i>) to withstand seasonal floods.

1.3

Structural Characteristics of Human Language (Hockett's Design Features)

Linguistic Architecture

While non-human organisms communicate via instinctual signals (e.g., honeybee waggle dances, vervet monkey alarm screams), human language possesses unique structural properties. In 1960, linguist Charles Hockett codified these as the universal **Design Features of Language**:

1. ARBITRARINESS (যাদৃচ্ছিকতা)

As Ferdinand de Saussure demonstrated, there is no natural, intrinsic connection between the acoustic **Signifier** (the sound sequence /*d-v-g*/) and the physical **Signified** (the four-legged barking canine). The association is established purely through societal convention. In Assamese it is *Kukur*, in Hindi *Kutta*, in Bodo *Sima*, and in French *Chien*.

Signifier (*Sound*)

Arbitrary Convention

Signified (*Concept*)

2. DUALITY OF PATTERNING (দ্বৈত বিন্যাস)

Language operates simultaneously on two hierarchical tiers: (1) A primary tier of discrete, meaningless individual sounds (*phonemes*, such as /*t*/, /*æ*/, /*k*/), and (2) A secondary tier where these meaningless sounds are recombined to generate meaningful lexical words (*morphemes*, such as *cat*, *act*, *tack*). This enables infinite lexical variety from small phonetic repertoires.

Level 1: {/k/, /æ/, /t/}

⇒

Level 2: "cat", "act"

3. CREATIVITY & RECURSION (সৃজনশীলতা)

Noam Chomsky highlighted that human language is creative and infinitely generative. Using a finite set of structural grammatical rules and a finite lexicon, a human child can generate and comprehend an **infinite number of novel sentences** that they have never previously heard or uttered in their life.

Finite Grammar Rules $\implies$ Infinite Novel Sentences

4. DISPLACEMENT (স্থান-কাল যুক্তি)

Animal communication is locked into the immediate spatial and chronological present (signaling immediate hunger or proximate danger). Human language can transcend immediate space and time, enabling speakers to discuss the distant past, plan future harvests, and ponder abstract philosophical concepts.

Capacity: Discuss [*Past, Future, Abstract, Imaginary*]

5. DYNAMIC EVOLUTION (গতিশীলতা)

Language is never static or terminal. It continuously assimilates loan words, modifies pronunciation, shifts syntactic preferences, and sheds obsolete vocabularies across historical epochs through cultural cross-pollination.

Evolutionary Velocity: $\Delta\text{Lexicon}/\Delta\text{Time} > 0$

6. CULTURAL TRANSMISSION (সাংস্কৃতিক সঞ্চারণ)

While the genetic predisposition to acquire human language is biologically pre-wired in the human brain (Chomsky's Universal Grammar), the specific language code (L_1) must be acquired through social interaction within a cultural linguistic community.

Biology (LAD) $\times$ Culture (Environment) = L_1

1.4 &
1.5

Language as Cultural Identity, The Sapir-Whorf Hypothesis & Cathartic Expression

Sociolinguistics

● Cultural Identity & Linguistic Relativity (Sapir-Whorf Hypothesis):

Formulated by anthropologists Edward Sapir and Benjamin Lee Whorf, the principle of **Linguistic Relativity** posits that the structural architecture of a language shapes how its native speakers categorize, perceive, and interpret reality:

Strong Determinism (Linguistic Determinism):

The controversial hypothesis asserting that language strictly determines thought patterns. While largely rejected by modern cognitive linguistics, its softer variant is widely recognized.

Weak Relativity (Linguistic Influence):

Acknowledges that language influences habitual modes of memory, color categorization, and spatial orientation. Indigenous vocabularies capture regional ecological knowledge (e.g., distinct Assamese terms for varied stages of paddy growth and bamboo splitting techniques).

● Vehicle of Emotional Catharsis and Dell Hymes' Communicative Competence:

Sociolinguist Dell Hymes introduced **Communicative Competence** to challenge Chomsky's purely grammatical view. Language is not just knowing dictionary definitions; it is knowing *when to speak, when to be silent, what tone to use, and how to adapt speech to diverse social contexts*:

Hymes' SPEAKING Model in Primary Classrooms:

- **S (Setting & Scene)**: Welcoming classroom spaces that encourage open questions.
- **P (Participants)**: Teacher-student peer dynamics free from verbal intimidation.
- **E (Ends)**: Achieving emotional validation alongside academic discovery.
- **A (Act Sequence)**: Encouraging spontaneous story-telling and shared dialogue.
- **K (Key)**: Tone of warmth, emotional comfort, and playful exploration.

2

Language Acquisition and Learning

Krashen's SLA Architecture, The FLN Continuum, Articulatory Phonetics & Morphological Syntax

Weightage:
10 Marks

2.1 &
2.2

Language Acquisition vs. Language Learning & The Home-to-School Transitional Bridge

Krashen's SLA Framework

Educational linguist Stephen Krashen established the distinction between how children acquire their first language (L_1) and how they learn subsequent school languages (L_2):

EVALUATIVE DIMENSION	LANGUAGE ACQUISITION (ভাষা অর্জন - L_1)	LANGUAGE LEARNING (ভাষা শিকন - L_2)
1. Psychological Process	Subconscious, natural, implicit, and effortless assimilation through daily home immersion.	Conscious, formal, explicit mental effort focusing on grammatical rules and formal syntax.
2. Environmental Context	Informal domestic ecosystem: caregiver attachment, family routines, play with peers.	Formal institutional classrooms, workbooks, teacher correction, and structured syllabi.
3. Role of Grammatical Rules	Intuitive procedural mastery. The child forms complex grammatical sentences without verbalizing formal grammar rules.	Explicit declarative knowledge. The learner memorizes parts of speech, conjugation tables, and spelling conventions.
4. Motivational Driver	Immediate biological and emotional need to express desires, bond, and understand surrounding adults.	Extrinsic scholastic performance: passing examinations, classroom approval, or career utility.

● **STEPHEN KRASHEN'S FIVE CORE SLA HYPOTHESES:**

1. Acquisition-Learning

Acquisition leads to communicative fluency; learning acts solely as an editor.

2. Natural Order

Grammatical structures are internalized in predictable, natural developmental stages.

3. The Monitor

Conscious grammar acts only as a monitor to check accuracy when time permits.

4. Comprehensible Input

Acquisition occurs when exposure is just beyond current level:

$$\text{Input} = i + 1$$

5. Affective Filter

High anxiety or fear blocks learning input from reaching the brain's language center.

The Home-to-School Transitional Dilemma:

When children enter primary school, banning their mother tongue (L_1) or dismissing their indigenous dialect induces an emotional shock known as **Subtractive Bilingualism**. This results in classroom anxiety, mutism, and high dropout rates. Under NEP 2020, educators must implement **Additive Bilingualism**, using the child's home language as a scaffold to build confidence in the standard school language (L_2).

Under the **National Initiative for Proficiency in Reading with Understanding and Numeracy (NIPUN Bharat)**, early literacy is prioritized: every primary child must attain foundational literacy by the end of Grade 3. Early reading is not mechanical letter decoding; it relies on five integrated developmental pillars:

Pillar 1**Oral Language**

Extensive conversations, rhymes, shared storytelling, and dialogic circle times building listening and oral fluency.

Pillar 2**Phonological Awareness**

The auditory ability to recognize, segment, blend, and manipulate speech sounds (alliteration, rhyme, syllable clapping).

Pillar 3**Decoding & Phonics**

Connecting spoken sounds (phonemes) to written letters (graphemes), developing stable sound-symbol correspondence.

Pillar 4**Reading Fluency**

Reading age-appropriate texts with accuracy, speed, and expression.

Grade 3: 45–60 WPM

Pillar 5**Comprehension**

Constructing meaning, evaluating story characters, identifying themes, and inferring real-world connections.

- **Phonetics and Phonology (ধ্বনিবিজ্ঞান):**

Phonemes vs. Allophones:

A *phoneme* is the smallest contrastive unit of speech sound distinguishing meaning (e.g., swapping /b/ for /p/ turns *pat* into *bat*). An *allophone* is a phonetic variation of a sound that does not change word meaning (e.g., aspirated [p^h] in *pin* vs. unaspirated [p] in *spin*).

Regional Phonological Contrasts:

Assamese features 8 distinct oral vowel phonemes (/i, e, ε, a, ɤ, ɔ, u/) and lacks retroflex stops, using alveolar articulations instead. Understanding this prevents teachers from misinterpreting regional pronunciations as learning deficits!

Supra-Segmental Features:

Covers stress, rhythm, and intonation. Indian languages are predominantly **syllable-timed** (each syllable takes roughly equal duration), whereas English is **stress-timed** (intervals between stressed syllables remain uniform).

- **Morphology and Syntax (ৰূপতত্ত্ব আৰু বাক্যতত্ত্ব):**

Free vs. Bound Morphemes:

A *morpheme* is the smallest meaningful grammatical unit. Free morphemes stand alone as independent words (*book, play, tree*). Bound morphemes are affixes attached to bases:

un- (prefix) + faith (root) + -ful (suffix) + -ly (suffix) = unfaithfully

Derivational vs. Inflectional Affixes:

Derivational affixes create new words or change word classes (teach [V] → teacher [N]).

Inflectional affixes mark grammatical tense, number, or case without altering word class (play → plays, played, playing).

Syntactic Typology (Word Order):

Languages differ fundamentally in syntactic structure:

Assamese / Hindi / Bodo: S – O – V (ল'ৰাটোৱে [S] ভাত [O] খাইছে [V])

English: S – V – O (The boy [S] eats [V] rice [O])

3.1

Constitutional Safeguards & Statutory Framework for Languages in India

Constitutional
Jurisprudence

The Constitution of India balances national integration with the fundamental cultural-linguistic rights of diverse linguistic groups:

ARTICLE 343

Declares Hindi in Devanagari script as the Official Language of the Union. English was retained for official transactions via the *Official Languages Act of 1963* as an Associate Official Language.

ARTICLE 345

Empowers State Legislatures to adopt any one or more languages in official use in the State (e.g., Assamese, Bengali, Bodo in Assam) for intra-state administrative functions.

ARTICLE 350A (CRUCIAL FOR D.EL.ED!)

Directs every State and local authority to ensure **adequate facilities for instruction in the mother tongue at the primary stage of education** to children belonging to linguistic minority groups.

ARTICLE 350B

Establishes the statutory office of the *Special Officer for Linguistic Minorities* appointed by the President of India to investigate safeguards and submit reports.

ARTICLE 351

Sets the duty of the Union to promote the spread of Hindi, drawing vocabulary primarily from Sanskrit and secondarily from other Indian languages without suppressing regional diversity.

THE EIGHTH SCHEDULE

Constitutional recognition of 22 major languages (originally 14). Includes Assamese, Bodo, Bengali, Hindi, Manipuri, Nepali, and Santali, granting cultural legitimacy and developmental funding.

The Multi-Ethnic Linguistic Map of Assam:

Assam represents an extraordinary convergence of major Asian language families:

- **Indo-Aryan Family:** Assamese, Sylheti/Bengali (Barak Valley), Bishnupriya Manipuri, Nepali.
- **Tibeto-Burman Family:** Bodo (8th Schedule), Mising, Karbi, Dimasa, Rabha, Tiwa, Garo.
- **Austro-Asiatic Roots:** Khasi/Pnar speaking pockets in border regions.
- **Contact Varieties & Creoles:** "Sadri" (tea garden community lingua franca), Nagamese, and Deshi varieties.

Multilingualism as a Cognitive Resource:

Research by Ellen Bialystok shows multilingual children develop heightened **Metalinguistic Awareness**, superior cognitive flexibility, and divergent problem-solving abilities earlier than monolingual peers.

Translanguaging Pedagogy (Ofelia García):

Translanguaging rejects the view that bilingual children possess two separate linguistic silos. Instead, bilinguals navigate a **single integrated linguistic repertoire**:

- **Classroom Practice:** Teachers allow students to discuss complex science concepts in their home dialect while reading textbooks in the standard language.
- **Multilingual Print Ecology:** Displaying classroom object labels in multiple languages (e.g., *Water* / পানী / দৈ / জল).

The Three-Language Formula (ত্ৰৈভাষিক সূত্ৰ):

Formulated by CABE (1956), confirmed by Kothari Commission (1964–66), and updated under NEP 2020:

- R_1 (**First Language**): Mother tongue or regional language (L_1) as medium of instruction.
- R_2 (**Second Language**): Hindi or English in non-Hindi speaking states; modern Indian language in Hindi states.
- R_3 (**Third Language**): English or a modern Indian language not studied as R_1 or R_2 .

NEP 2020 emphasizes flexibility: no language is imposed, and at least two of the three chosen languages must be native to India.

4.1 & 4.2 Concept, Rationale of LAC & Disciplinary Literacy

Bullock Report (1975)

The **Language Across the Curriculum (LAC)** approach originated from the landmark British committee report titled "*A Language for Life*" (The Bullock Report, 1975). It established that **every teacher is a language teacher**, because every academic discipline relies on language to structure, evaluate, and communicate its knowledge.

1. LEARNING LANGUAGE

Acquiring the linguistic mechanics: phonetics, syntax, punctuation, spelling, and literary expression during dedicated language classes.

2. LEARNING THROUGH LANGUAGE

Using language as an investigative tool to analyze historical sources, question scientific hypotheses, debate ethics, and solve math problems.

3. DISCIPLINARY REGISTERS

Mastering specialized vocabulary and sentence structures unique to specific fields (e.g., reading a poem requires different interpretive strategies than reading a chemistry lab report).

4.3 & 4.4 Halliday's 7 Language Functions and Jim Cummins' BICS vs. CALP Architecture

Theoretical
Diagnostics**M.A.K. Halliday's Seven Functional Categories of Early Language:****1. Instrumental ("I want")**

Expressing immediate physical needs, hunger, or practical requests.

2. Regulatory ("Do as I say")

Directing the actions of peers, issuing rules, and managing play routines.

3. Interactional ("Me and you")

Social bonding, sharing greetings, welcoming peers, building rapport.

4. Personal ("Here I am")

Expressing unique individuality, pride, personal feelings, and opinions.

5. Heuristic ("Tell me why")

Asking exploratory questions, investigating nature, probing scientific anomalies.

6. Imaginative ("Let's pretend")

Socio-dramatic pretend play, storytelling, inventing jokes, writing verses.

7. Representational / Informative ("I have information")

Communicating academic propositions, empirical data, and factual concepts.

Jim Cummins' Dual Iceberg Hypothesis (BICS vs. CALP):

Professor Jim Cummins cautions educators against conflating conversational fluency with academic language mastery:

EVALUATIVE FEATURE	BICS (BASIC INTERPERSONAL COMMUNICATIVE SKILLS)	CALP (COGNITIVE ACADEMIC LANGUAGE PROFICIENCY)
1. Nature of Discourse	Playground language, social chit-chat, conversational exchanges supported by hand gestures and physical surroundings.	Formal academic language required to read abstract textbooks, compose analytical essays, and solve math problems.
2. Contextual Support	Context-Embedded: Meaning is supported by facial expressions, physical props, and immediate peer feedback.	Context-Reduced: Minimal interpersonal cues; meaning must be decoded entirely from written academic syntax.
3. Cognitive Load	Cognitively Undemanding: Familiar words, straightforward syntax, informal register.	Cognitively Demanding: Higher-order thinking skills (HOTS), specialized terminology, synthesis, and abstract logic.
4. Acquisition Timeline	Typically acquired within 1 to 2 years of environmental exposure.	Requires 5 to 7 years of explicit, sustained pedagogical scaffolding to achieve grade-level parity!

Pedagogical Warning for Primary Teachers:

Just because a first-generation or linguistic minority student chats comfortably in the schoolyard (*BICS*) does not mean they are ready to read an expository science passage without support (*CALP*). Educators must bridge this gap using graphic organizers, vocabulary banks, and conceptual modeling!

PAPER S1.3 CONTINUOUS INTERNAL ASSESSMENT BLUEPRINT

Total: 15 Internal Marks • Practical Application & Fieldwork

Session 2026

Practicum Tasks & Portfolio Submission

10 Marks ($5 \times 2 = 10$)

Task 1 (Compulsory) + Any 1 Prescribed Option

Institutional Written Unit Test

5 Marks

Evaluates Theoretical & Linguistic Mastery

PRESCRIBED PRACTICUM ASSIGNMENT TASKS:

- **Task 1 (Compulsory – 5 Marks):** Participate in and facilitate oral literary events such as classroom debates, extempore speeches, storytelling circles, and socio-dramatic role-play showcasing expressive discourse.
- **Task 2 (Phonics & TLM – 5 Marks):** Design engaging, low-cost pictorial charts illustrating vowel-consonant phonemic ladders, minimal pair contrasts, or word-family wheels for early reading in primary classes.
- **Task 3 (Dialect Survey – 5 Marks):** Conduct a linguistic neighborhood survey documenting the home languages and community dialects spoken across 15 households in a local village or school catchment area.
- **Task 4 (Folk Heritage Collection – 5 Marks):** Collect, transcribe, and pedagogically annotate 10 traditional folk rhymes, lullabies (*Nisukoni Geet*), or community proverbs across varied ethnic communities in Assam.
- **Task 5 (Multilingual Case Study – 5 Marks):** Prepare an analytical case study detailing the linguistic challenges and translanguaging strategies observed in a real multilingual primary classroom.

SCHOOL INTERNSHIP (SIP-I LINKAGE – 2 WEEKS):

During School Internship-I, student-teachers audit the classroom linguistic ecology of their allotted school. Trainees assess children's oral fluency in the home dialect, screen foundational phonemic awareness, implement translanguaging bridges to assist quiet students, and compile a reflective observation report countersigned by the head teacher.

Paper S1.3 Master Study Notes • Curriculum Session 2026

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